

A CALL OF CTHULHU ONE-SHOT

The Blooming

Keeper's Reference

30 SEPTEMBER 1921 · DUNWICH, MASSACHUSETTS

3-5 investigators · ~4 hours · one sitting

Four horticulturists answer an invitation to watch a rare orchid bloom.

There is no orchid society. The bloom is a clock.

KEEPER-ONLY DOSSIER · dndnight.org

AT - A - GLANCE RUN SHEET

Run the Night in One Page

Keep this page open. The five acts below darken as they go — do not spend your best horror early. Dread meters (●●●○○) pace your descriptions.

ACT	WHERE	BEAT	DREAD
I	Dunwich, dusk	A rotting town; Zebulon rushes them up Sentinel Hill. Cozy, then three quiet wrongnesses.	●●○○○
II	The Chateau · Study	Reginald greets them. Books on Bloody Mary, the crystal, the two grimoires. Wait for midnight.	●●●○○
III	Ground floor	Blood drains east. The calendar puzzle. The orchid blooms; Reginald locks them in.	●●●●○
IV	Master Suite	Mother — the birthing vessel. The genre changes at the table.	●●●●●
V	Deck · Dungeon	Family portraits. The Communicator. The Name. The Soul Organ.	●●●●●
END	The grounds	Reginald, naked beneath the maelstrom: “Welcome to a new birth.” Cut to black.	●●●●●

THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER

The premise is banal on purpose. Your players are hobbyists lured by a flower — not soldiers. Play the first hour almost cozy so the wrongness arrives in a room they thought was safe.

OPEN THE SESSION WITH THREE LINES (OUT OF CHARACTER)

“This is not D&D. Bravery can get you killed. And by the end of tonight, at least one of you will not be entirely yourself.”

Then explain Sanity once (table below) and never explain it again.

The Secret Truth

Everything the investigators will spend four hours failing to understand.

WHO IS Y'GOLONAC

A Great Old One in the shape of a naked, headless body — palms opening into hungering mouths. God of the depraved and the buried. He cannot walk the world in his own form; he needs a **vessel of the correct bloodline, opened at the correct hour.**

THE BLOODY MARY CONSPIRACY

In 1553, on **30 September**, Mary I became England's first crowned queen — through sacrifice to Y'gonolac. Her reign of blood was tribute. He had arranged Lady Jane Grey's beheading to make Mary his vessel, but Mary's death in 1558 cheated him of the birth. Enraged, he swore to burst from his stone tomb on the **third first-of-October under a new moon** and consume all of Mary's line.

MOTHER, AND THE 1845 EVENT

Y'gonolac last emerged in **1845**, possessing the Lady of this estate. Forced out, what remained was **Mother** — no longer a person, a semi-lucid husk kept alive to birth Dark Ones. She is strapped to a bed in the Master Suite, still whispering. The Household has tended the bloodline and the calendar ever since.

THE INVESTIGATORS ARE THE POINT

They were not invited for a flower. Each is a distant descendant of Mary's line — that is how the Household knew their names. The orchid is a countdown. The house is the womb. **Reginald is the midwife.**

The calendar puzzle — untangled

Players find scattered lunar notes and get confused. That is intended. Here is the version you never lose:

DATE / YEAR	WHAT IT MEANS
30 Sept	Anniversary of Mary's coronation — the god's "birthday."
1 Oct, new moon	The only night the seal can break. Y'gonolac's vow was sworn against this date. **This is tonight.**
31 Oct	A red herring the cult itself chased. Halloween is a human invention; the god does not keep it.
1845	Last successful emergence — produced Mother.
1902	New moon fell on both 1 Oct and 31 Oct, yet "no event" — the bloodline wasn't present.
1959	The next alignment after tonight. Stop this one and the Household simply waits.

Arrival at Dunwich

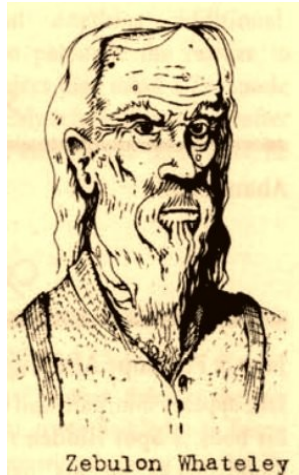
Each investigator makes their own way to Dunwich. However they arrive, the town greets them the same: a dilapidated center, buildings barely held together by rot and vines, the bones of a place surrendering to the forest. An air of destitution. Let a player ask the question the town begs — *why is anyone still here?* — and give no answer.

COZY, THEN WRONG

Play Act I gentle. Let the horticulturists geek out, compare invitations, discover their shared obsession. Seed **three quiet wrongnesses** and never underline them:

- ① nobody in town will meet their eyes; ② the estate is only ever called “up there,” never by name; ③ the invitations are all in the same hand, though received separately.

■ Zebulon Whately — the guide



ZEBULON WHATELY · WILL NOT WALK THEM UP THE HILL

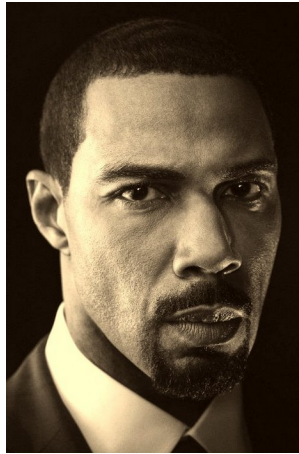
The investigators assemble at **Osborn's General Store** as the sun goes down. Zebulon gives directions up to the chateau, deep in the forest atop **Old Sentinel Hill**. He is not talkative. He wants these people up and out of his town as fast as possible. Every answer is vague to the point of uselessness. He will not walk them up. He does not expect them to come back down.

IF PLAYERS PUSH ZEBULON

“Folk who go up for the flower don't come down. Company's been going up longer'n the town's been dyin'. You want my advice? Miss it.”

Then he closes the store.

The Chateau & the Study



REGINALD · THE BUTLER / THE MIDWIFE

■ Reginald greets them

At the door stands Reginald — stoic, exacting, respectful. He ushers each arrival to the Study and withdraws; near midnight he returns to collect them. Play him as a man doing a job he only half understands. He does not know who owns the house. His instructions simply *appear*: once a week a schedule is left on a board in the Laundry, from a source he has never seen and will not discuss.

REGINALD'S ARC — PLANT IT NOW

He seems the one sane fixture in the house. That is the setup. His warmth is real and his ignorance is real — which makes his final turn land like a trapdoor. Give the players a reason to trust him tonight so it costs them later.

■ The Study — read aloud

Three walls are lined floor to ceiling with bookshelves: periodicals, dusty tomes, some bound in a leather you would not care to name. The fourth wall — nearest the Master Bedroom — is different. Accent lights converge from every angle on a single small **white crystal**, and to either side a reading table displays one book each, positioned to be found.

THE ROOM IS A SOFT LOCK

Later the investigators are shut in here and must find the way out. The exit into the **Master Suite** opens only when the *Zanthu Tablets* are lifted from their table — a hidden mechanism engages. Anyone with **SPOT 15+** hears it click.

■ On the shelves — the Mary thread

- Volumes on Mary I: her life, her death, and — in lurid detail — how she tortured those she named heretics.
- Dark-arts texts claiming her death “foretold the coming of a great beast.”
- Marginalia puzzling over why **1 October** and **30 September** matter, and why **31 October** “doesn’t make sense.”

- Tucked in one book: a half-disintegrated photo of a Civil War soldier, dated **31 October 1865**. On the back: “ceremony — did it take?”



FOUND PRESSED IN A TOME · 31 OCT 1865

■ The Crystal of the Elders

A shining white crystal swirling with contained power. Examination: **0/1 Sanity**. Picking it up “activates” it: **1d2/5d4 ability-score damage**, randomized across abilities by 1d4 each. On being lifted it **disintegrates** into white spores — one random investigator drops unconscious for **1d10 minutes**.

USE THE UNCONSCIOUSNESS

The spore-sleep is a gift to pacing. Drop a player under right before a scare, and let them wake to something already wrong — the others gone quiet, a door now open, Reginald standing too close.

■ The Tomes — grimoires in disguise

The two displayed books, and others found by searching, are functional grimoires. Reading them is dangerous; casting from them is worse. Full spell mechanics are in the Reference tables at the back.

TOME	SANITY (EXAMINE / READ)	WHAT IT HOLDS
Zanthu Tablets <i>carvings dredged from the Pacific</i>	0/1d3 · then 1/1d6	Triggers the Master-Suite lock. Holds Eye of Light & Darkness, Dominate Soul.
Pnakotic Manuscript <i>prehistoric, possibly pre-human</i>	1d4 · then 1d8	Holds Create Time Gate, Contact Y'gononac.

The House Wakes

If the investigators wander before midnight — or after they escape the Study — the chateau opens room by room. Each space adds one piece of the truth. The house is confident it will keep them.

The Grand Room

Faint blood-stains, scrubbed many times, nearly invisible against dark wood. Not decoration — *directional*.

TO NOTICE	SEARCH (ACTIVE)	SPOT (PASSIVE)
The stains at all	18+	23+
They “drain” toward the EAST wall	20+	25+
THE EAST WALL IS A PROMISE Everything flows east and down — toward the Master Suite, the Deck, the dungeon beneath. When a player traces the blood east, let them feel the pull of the architecture. The house has a stomach, and it's downhill.		

Sitting Room & Conservatory

- **Sitting Room** — the door to the Master Suite is locked until the Zanthu Tablets are lifted in the Study.
- **Conservatory** — the calendar puzzle room. A sandstone stand set deliberately *just* off-center. Around its center, in an unbroken ring, runs the script below.

HANDOUT · SANDSTONE SCRIPT

31st Octobers bring forth the final seal — from sky He comes and the end He brings

Lunar charts paper every surface. Among the notes: “*New moon.*” · “*next halloween with new moon: 1959.*” · “*1902: no event.*” · “*Explain 1845??*”

LET THEM SOLVE THE WRONG PUZZLE

The sandstone and the 1959/Halloween notes point at **31 October** — the trail the cult itself burned years on. Clever players will fixate on it. It is a dead end. The real date is tonight, 1 October, new moon. While they decode the wrong Halloween, midnight comes for the right one.

The Fountain & the Orchid

At the heart of the grounds, the Rothschild's orchid stands wrapped in strange light. When it blooms at midnight, the sky splits into a slow maelstrom of purple and red. The instant it opens, **Reginald appears** to escort the group “back to the Study for the viewing” — where he locks them in. The night has begun.

Mother

Having escaped the Study through the mechanism, the investigators step into the Master Suite and find what the house has been feeding. This is the hinge of the night. Everything before was atmosphere.



SUBJECT: "MOTHER" · DO NOT APPROACH

Strapped to the bed is a grotesque female form — an indistinct mass of sinew and fluid, headless, with mouths where hands should be. The bed is a swamp of gore. She births foul, half-formed things and repeats one shrieked line:

MOTHER SPEAKS

"Care for the brood! CARE FOR THE BROOD!"

Sanity on sight: **1d4 / 2d4**.

RESTRAINT IS THE HORROR

Describe Mother in three precise strokes, then stop. The pause after "mouths where her hands should be" is worse than any fourth sentence. Body-horror lands hardest when it is specific and brief. Watch the table — if someone's rattled, that's the effect working, not a reason to pile on.

The same directional stains reappear — this time easy to spot, dragging toward the **northern wall and the Deck beyond**. The house is still pointing downhill.

Beneath the House

■ The Northern Deck

Hidden in the deck boards is a trapdoor down into the dungeon.

ACTION	THRESHOLD
SPOT the door	20+
SEARCH (active)	17+
Force it (STR)	20+
Read the runes (Occult)	Knowledge 15+



TRAPDOOR GLYPHS · THE OPENING RITE

The runes describe an ancient power mankind has tried, again and again, to enslave — and how every time it is the power that ends up owning the men. By now the investigators can name what this house is: a cult, and an old one.

■ The Dungeon

Walls lined with runes telling the story of the coming dark. Everything algae-slick, cobwebbed, filthy — and **hot**. Unnaturally, wrongly hot. Read the rooms slow; let the players feel the temperature climb.

THE CONFERENCE ROOM — THE GUT-PUNCH

Just left of the entry: portraits dating to the founding of the colonies, early 1600s onward. Among the old faces the investigators find **their own families** — a grandparent here, a parent there. This is where a smart table realizes they were bred for tonight. Let it dawn in silence. The portraits are the explanation.

■ The Temporal Communicator



THE TEMPORAL COMMUNICATOR

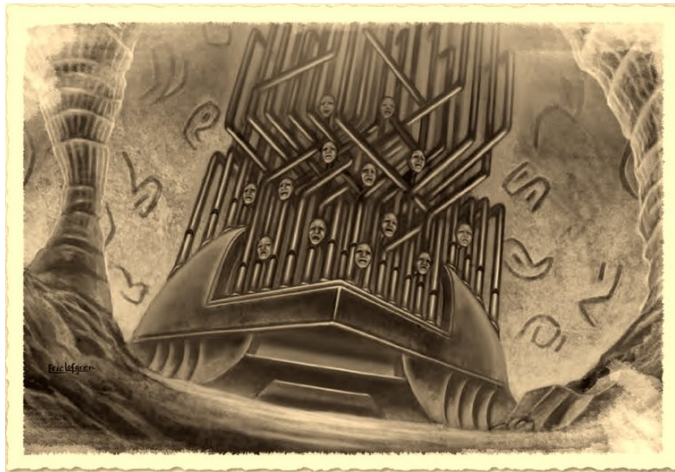
An intricate brass device topped with a red jewel attuned to Y'gononac. Touch the jewel and it wakes; after **1d4 minutes** a hologram of the god projects from the stone. To see Y'gononac's true form costs **1d20 Sanity** outright. Reading the surrounding runes: **0/1d4**. They name the horror — a name so vulgar that hearing it costs **1/1d6** more:

THE NAME

Y'GOLONAC

Once the name is known, every investigator gains **+5 Mythos**. There is no unknowing it.

■ The Soul Organ



THE SOUL ORGAN · THE FATE OF EVERY GUEST BEFORE THEM

In the last room waits the Soul Organ. Looking at it: **1/1d6 Sanity**. It writhes in agony; a mass of faces, each turning to glare into every investigator's eyes. They know English. They can converse. And everything they say is broken past sense.

HANDOUT · THE FACES SPEAK

"We are sorrow... you'll feel it too."

"He knows what makes you cry."

"Fly with the voids of darkness and hear the whispers."

"Your soul smells delectable."

"Devour. DEVOUR."

DELIVER THE WHISPERS WRONG ON PURPOSE

Read these out of order. Overlap them. Assign each line to a different face and let them talk over one another. The horror isn't the words — it's that the faces *want* to communicate and can't, and one of them, if the investigators linger, starts to sound like someone they recognize.

A New Birth

While the investigators were locked in the Study, they heard Reginald outside, murmuring to someone unseen. Then screaming. Then a wet, heavy *splloosh*, and blood seeping under the door (**0/1 Sanity**). They assumed the worst had happened *to* him. It hadn't. It happened *through* him.

THE FINAL IMAGE

When the investigators reach the exit from the dungeon, they emerge to find Reginald standing naked beneath the vast maelstrom, gazing up in rapture. He hears them, turns, and — with a wide, gentle, genuinely welcoming smile — says the last words of the night:

“Welcome... to a new birth.”

Cut to black there. Do not narrate what comes next. The investigators arrived exactly on schedule, and the house has what it invited. **This is how the scenario ends.**

ESCALATING THE FINALE (OPTIONAL)

If your table wants a fight: let them *try* to stop it and fail meaningfully. The **Eye of Light and Darkness** spell weakens every Mythos creature within a mile and blocks Domination — cast four hours before moonrise, it could have unmade the ritual. By the time they understand, it's minutes to midnight. Give them the tool too late. Tragedy beats a boss fight here.

Reference Tables

The four spells

SPELL	COST	EFFECT
Eye of Light & Darkness <i>Zanthu · #1</i>	2 CON (perm) · 1d8 San to all in range	Cast 4 hrs before moonrise; needs blood of an innocent (0 Mythos). Weakens all Mythos creatures within 1 mile; blocks Dominate. The one thing that could stop tonight.
Dominate Soul <i>Zanthu · #2</i>	2 WIS · 1d6 San	Target resists with WIS 17+. On success, control the soul for 1 day/level (~3 days).
Create Time Gate <i>Pnakotic · #3</i>	1 STR + 1 San per rank	Opens a gate through time. Distance scales ×10 per STR drained — see table.
Contact Y'gononac <i>Pnakotic</i>	1 WIS (perm) · 1d10 San · +1d20 on waking	Opens a channel to the god. Caster collapses 1d10 min into horrifying visions. You do not want this to succeed.

Create Time Gate — distance by STR drained

STR	YEARS	STR	YEARS
1	100	8	1 billion
2	1,000	9	10 billion
3	10,000	10	100 billion
4	100,000	11	1 trillion
5	1 million	12	10 trillion
6	10 million	13	100 trillion
7	100 million	14–15	1–10 quadrillion

Every rank is ×10. Reaching 1553 would gut an investigator — which is the point. The past is reachable, and it costs your body to touch it.

Sanity toll — quick tally

ENCOUNTER	SANITY (FAIL / SUCCESS OR EXAMINE / COMPLETE)
Crystal of the Elders (examine)	0/1
Zanthu Tablets	0/1d3 · then 1/1d6
Pnakotic Manuscript	1d4 · then 1d8
Mother, on sight	1d4 / 2d4
Reginald's "death" (blood under the door)	0/1
Dungeon runes / the Name	0/1d4 · then 1/1d6
Soul Organ	1/1d6
Y'gononac's true form (Communicator)	1d20

■ Cast of the house

- **Reginald** — the butler. Sincere, exacting, ignorant by design. The house's hands. Opens the way at midnight and welcomes the dawn of "a new birth."
- **Mother** — the 1845 vessel, hollowed out and kept alive to birth Dark Ones. Says only: "Care for the brood."
- **Zebulon Whately** — Dunwich guide. Knows exactly what the hill is; gets them there fast. Will not follow.
- **Y'gononac** — Great Old One. Headless body, mouths in the palms. Wants in through Mary's blood on the new moon of 1 October.
- **The Household** — never seen, possibly never real. Reginald's schedule appears from nowhere. The true master is the god below.

TABLE REFERENCE

For random unsettling phenomena as the night escalates, roll on **Strange Events** — Table 7-1, p.122 (PDF) / p.120 (print) of the core rulebook.